

Week 8

Civics & Community Engagement

Critical Thinking · Media Literacy · Community Service Project Management



Course Modules at a Glance

MODULE A

Critical Thinking & Media Literacy

- Cognitive biases (confirmation, in-group)
- How propaganda works
- Deepfakes & digital manipulation
- Evaluating sources: credibility checklist

MODULE B

Community Service Project Management

- Identifying community challenges
- Stakeholder mapping
- Community needs assessment
- Designing surveys & interview techniques

M O D U L E A

Critical Thinking & Media Literacy

Cognitive Biases · Propaganda · Deepfakes · Evaluating Sources

Cognitive Biases That Shape Civic Opinions

What is a Cognitive Bias? A cognitive bias is a systematic pattern of deviation from rational thinking. Our brains use mental shortcuts (heuristics) to process information quickly — but these shortcuts can cause predictable errors in how we interpret news, politics, and social issues.

Confirmation Bias

Definition:

The tendency to search for, interpret, and remember information that confirms your pre-existing beliefs — while ignoring or dismissing information that contradicts them.

Examples:

- Scrolling only through news sources you already agree with
- Sharing articles that support your political view without checking accuracy
- Ignoring statistics that challenge your opinion on an issue

Civic Impact: In civic life, confirmation bias polarises communities. Citizens stop engaging with opposing viewpoints and instead live in 'echo chambers' where only one perspective is reinforced. This weakens democratic debate.

In-Group Bias

Definition:

The tendency to favour members of your own group (political party, ethnicity, religion, neighbourhood) over outsiders — even when the outsiders' arguments are objectively stronger.

Examples:

- Trusting a politician's claims more because they are from your party
- Dismissing a policy idea because it comes from a rival group
- Evaluating the same action as acceptable or unacceptable depending on who did it

Civic Impact: In-group bias drives tribalism in politics and civil society. It makes it harder to build coalitions across differences, undermines fair evaluation of policy, and can escalate into discrimination.

Biases in Action: The Feedback Loop



⚠ Key Insight: This cycle does not require bad intentions. It operates automatically and unconsciously. Social media algorithms actively exploit these biases by showing you content you're likely to engage with — reinforcing your existing views and deepening polarisation.

How to Break the Cycle:

Seek out opposing views

Deliberately read sources you disagree with

Pause before sharing

Ask: Is this accurate, or does it just feel good to share?

Check your sources

Verify claims through multiple independent outlets

Question your group

Be willing to disagree with your own side when the facts demand it

How Propaganda Works: Emotional Triggers & Identity Targeting

What is Propaganda? Propaganda is communication designed to influence attitudes and behaviour by appealing to emotions and group identity rather than logic and evidence. It is not always a lie — propaganda works by selecting, framing, and amplifying certain truths while suppressing others.

Emotional Triggers

Fear

Exaggerates threats to make audiences feel unsafe, pushing them toward extreme solutions. Example: 'If we don't act now, our way of life will be destroyed.'

Outrage / Anger

Portrays an out-group as villainous or corrupt to mobilise anger. Outrage spreads faster on social media than any other emotion.

Pride & Nostalgia

Appeals to a glorified past or national/group identity to justify exclusionary policies. Example: slogans that invoke a 'golden age' that must be restored.

Hope & Urgency

Promises a utopian outcome if action is taken immediately, bypassing critical analysis. Creates a false sense that there is no time to question.

Identity Targeting

In-Group Flattery

Makes the audience feel morally superior to 'outsiders.' Reinforces the idea that their group is uniquely wise, virtuous, or under threat.

Scapegoating

Blames a minority group or outsider for complex social problems. Provides a simple, emotionally satisfying (but false) explanation for difficult issues.

Us vs. Them Framing

Divides the world into two sides. Nuance and complexity are eliminated. You must choose a side — neutrality is presented as betrayal.

Cultural Symbols

Uses flags, religious imagery, national heroes, or slogans to create deep emotional association without rational argument.

Recognising Propaganda: Common Techniques

Name-Calling

Using loaded, negative labels to discredit a person or idea without any supporting evidence. Attacks the person, not the argument.

Watch for: insults instead of facts

Glittering Generalities

Using vague but emotionally positive language — 'freedom,' 'justice,' 'our values' — to gain approval without specific commitments.

Watch for: big words with no clear meaning

Transfer

Associating a person or idea with a respected symbol (flag, religion, celebrity) to transfer positive emotions onto them.

Watch for: famous images used as backdrops

Bandwagon

'Everyone is doing it' — creates social pressure to join. Exploits the human desire to belong to the winning group.

Watch for: 'majority,' 'everyone knows'

False Dilemma

Presents only two extreme options when many exist. Eliminates middle ground and forces a binary choice.

Watch for: 'Either you're with us or against us'

Card Stacking

Presents only the facts and evidence that support one side while deliberately omitting contradictory information.

Watch for: one-sided statistics or cherry-picked data

✦ Critical literacy tip: Propagandists combine multiple techniques simultaneously. Train yourself to ask: 'What evidence is being left out? Who benefits from me believing this?'

Deepfakes & Digital Manipulation: What Citizens Must Know

What is a Deepfake? A deepfake is synthetic media (video, audio, or image) generated by artificial intelligence to make it appear that a real person said or did something they never actually did. The term comes from 'deep learning' + 'fake.' Unlike old-fashioned editing, deepfakes can be extremely convincing and are increasingly cheap and fast to produce.

Types of Deepfake Content

Face-Swap Videos



A person's face is replaced with another's in video footage. A politician appears to give a speech they never gave. A public figure appears in compromising situations.

Audio Cloning



AI replicates someone's voice from just a few seconds of audio. Fake phone calls, fake speeches, or fake confessions can be generated in minutes.

Image Synthesis



Entirely fabricated photos of real people or events. 'Photographs' of protests, crimes, or disasters that never happened.

Text Manipulation



AI-generated text mimicking a person's writing style, used to create fake quotes, fake articles, or fake official communications.

⚠ Deepfakes are dangerous because our brains are wired to trust video and audio evidence. We assume 'seeing is believing' — deepfakes exploit this assumption.

Spotting Deepfakes & Manipulation: Warning Signs

Visual & Technical Warning Signs

Unnatural eye movements

Blinking patterns look robotic; eye colour shifts across frames

Facial boundary blurring

Edges around the face, hair, or ears may shimmer or blur, especially in motion

Lighting inconsistencies

Shadow falls from different directions on the face vs. the background

Audio mismatch

Lip sync is slightly off; voice quality differs from background sound; vowels or consonants distorted

Unnatural skin texture

Skin looks too smooth, or shows sudden blemishes or wrinkles that

Context & Behavioural Warning Signs

Published on unknown sites

No credible, established news organisation has reported the same event or story

Amplified by bots

The content received thousands of shares suspiciously quickly, particularly from new or anonymous accounts

Timing is too convenient

Content appears just before an election, major vote, or during a crisis — designed to cause maximum impact

Extreme behaviour

The public figure shown behaves in an extreme, out-of-character way with no prior context

No original source

Nobody can trace the video to an original, datable event or live

 **What to do:** Do not share the content. Search for the original source. Use reverse image/video search tools (like TinEye or InVID). Check whether authoritative fact-checking organisations have reviewed it.

Evaluating Sources: The Credibility Checklist

In an era of misinformation and deepfakes, a citizen's most important skill is knowing how to evaluate whether a source is credible before accepting or sharing information. The AEMT framework provides a reliable, repeatable process for any piece of content.

A AUTHOR

- Who wrote or produced this content?
- What are their qualifications and expertise?
- Are they identified clearly, or is the content anonymous?
- Have they covered this topic accurately before?

✓ **Good:** Named expert with verifiable credentials, academic or professional background in the subject

✗ **Watch for:** Anonymous content, AI-generated bylines, known partisan bloggers with no subject expertise

E EVIDENCE

- What specific facts, data, or studies are cited?
- Are claims supported with verifiable references?
- Can you find and independently read the original sources?
- Are the statistics current and from legitimate organisations?

✓ **Good:** Peer-reviewed studies, government statistics, named witnesses, official documents

✗ **Watch for:** Vague phrases like 'experts say,' 'studies show,' or 'many people believe' with no citation

M MOTIVE

- Who funded or published this content and why?
- Does the publisher have a financial or political interest in your believing this?
- Is the platform trying to sell you something or change your vote?
- Is this content designed to inform or to inflame?

✓ **Good:** Nonprofit journalism with editorial independence, academic institutions, official government bodies

✗ **Watch for:** Content funded by a political party, industry lobbying group, or anonymous dark-money source

T TRIANGULATION

- Are multiple credible sources reporting the same thing?
- Do sources with opposing views still agree on the basic facts?
- What are trustworthy opposing sources saying?
- Is this story absent from all mainstream outlets?

✓ **Good:** Confirmed by 3+ independent outlets with different ownership and editorial perspectives

✗ **Watch for:** Only one source, or multiple outlets all derived from the same single original claim

Module A Summary: The Informed Citizen Checklist

- ☐ 1 Before I accept a claim, I ask: does this confirm what I already believe? (Confirmation Bias check)
- ☐ 2 Before I dismiss a claim, I ask: am I rejecting this only because it comes from 'the other side'? (In-Group Bias check)
- ☐ 3 I can identify the emotional trigger being used in this message (fear, outrage, pride, hope)
- ☐ 4 I can identify who is targeted and what identity is being activated in this message
- ☐ 5 I have checked whether this video/image/audio shows signs of digital manipulation
- ☐ 6 I know the Author: who made this and are they credible?
- ☐ 7 I have checked the Evidence: are specific, verifiable sources cited?
- ☐ 8 I understand the Motive: who benefits from me believing this and why?
- ☐ 9 I have Triangulated: at least 3 independent credible outlets confirm the same facts

M O D U L E B

Community Service Project Management

Community Challenges · Stakeholder Mapping · Needs Assessment · Surveys & Interviews

What We Will Cover in This Module

01



Problem vs. Symptom

Why treating visible signs without finding root causes leads to failed projects. Learn to dig deeper with the 5 Whys technique.

02



Stakeholder Mapping

Identify who supports, opposes, and benefits from your project. Use the Power–Interest matrix to prioritise your engagement.

03



Needs Assessment

Systematically measure what a community actually needs — not what you assume — before designing your intervention.

04



Survey Design

Choose the right question types, avoid the most common mistakes, and collect data you can actually analyse.

05



Interview Techniques

Master probing questions, maintain neutrality, and uphold ethical standards including informed consent.

Identifying Community Challenges: Problem vs. Symptom

The most common mistake in community projects is treating the symptom as if it were the problem. Projects that address only symptoms provide temporary relief but do not produce lasting change. Effective project management begins with identifying the root cause.

Symptom

Definition:

A symptom is the visible, surface-level sign that something is wrong. Symptoms are what the community feels and sees. They are the results of an underlying problem.

Identifying Cues:

- What you can easily observe
- What community members complain about first
- What a quick solution would temporarily fix

Examples:

- High school dropout rates
- Frequent street flooding
- High rates of youth unemployment
- Vandalism and graffiti in public spaces

Root Cause / Problem

Definition:

The root cause (or problem) is the underlying reason the symptom exists. Addressing the root cause produces sustainable change. Root causes are usually structural, systemic, or behavioural.

Identifying Cues:

- What you find by asking 'why?' multiple times
- What would need to change to make the symptom disappear permanently
- Often involves policy, systems, or deep social factors

Examples:

- Inadequate or inaccessible secondary schooling
- Outdated drainage infrastructure + poor urban planning
- Mismatch between skills training and local job market
- Lack of safe, engaging public spaces and youth programming

Drilling Down to the Root Cause: The '5 Whys' Technique

The 5 Whys is a root cause analysis technique: simply keep asking 'why?' until you reach a structural or systemic cause that, if addressed, would actually solve the problem. Developed in manufacturing, it is widely used in community development, public health, and social work.

Observation:

Children in our neighbourhood are missing school frequently.

Why? (1):

Because many feel unsafe walking to school.

Why? (2):

Because two main streets have no footpaths and heavy traffic.

Why? (3):

Because municipal infrastructure budget has not been allocated to this area.

Why? (4):

Because this neighbourhood is underrepresented in local government and has no strong civic advocacy.

Why? (5) → Root Cause:

Because communities here lack civic engagement skills, organised voice, and access to decision-making processes.

Tip: You may need more or fewer than 5 steps — keep going until you reach something structural that, if changed, would prevent the symptom from returning.

Stakeholder Mapping: Who Matters, Who Blocks, Who Benefits

What is a Stakeholder? Any individual, group, or organisation that is affected by your project OR that has the power to affect your project. Ignoring stakeholders — even hostile ones — is one of the most common reasons community projects fail.

Who MATTERS (Key Deciders)

People whose support is essential for the project to proceed or succeed. They often control resources, permissions, or legitimacy.

Typically includes:

- Government officials / elected representatives
- Department heads with budget authority
- Community elders or respected leaders
- Institutional gatekeepers (school principals, clinic directors)

Strategy: Engage early. Build trust. Keep them informed. Address their concerns before they become obstacles.

Who BLOCKS (Potential Resisters)

Individuals or groups who may actively oppose, slow down, or undermine your project — often because they perceive a threat to their interests or authority.

Typically includes:

- Competing organisations with overlapping mandates
- Political opponents of project sponsors
- Community members who distrust outside intervention
- Businesses whose profit depends on the status quo

Strategy: Never ignore them. Understand their objections. Involve them in planning where possible. Address their concerns directly.

Who BENEFITS (Direct Beneficiaries)

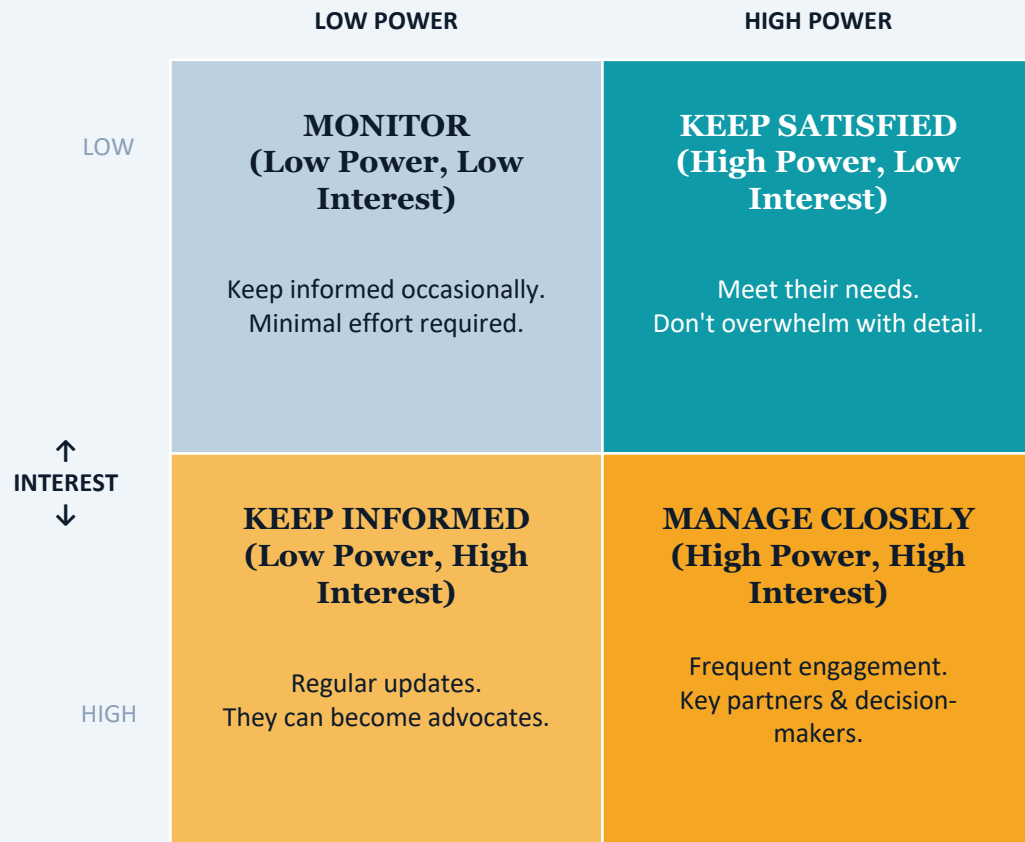
The people whose lives should improve as a direct result of the project. Their input is essential — projects designed without beneficiaries often miss the real need.

Typically includes:

- Target community members (by age, gender, location)
- Families and households affected by the issue
- Marginalised or underserved sub-groups
- Future generations (for environmental or infrastructure projects)

Strategy: Centre their voices. Involve them in design. Measure success by their outcomes, not project outputs.

The Power–Interest Matrix: Prioritising Stakeholder Engagement



How to Use This Matrix

1

List all stakeholders

Brainstorm everyone who could be affected by or affect your project.

2

Rate each stakeholder

Score them on Power (authority/resources) and Interest (how much they care) from Low to High.

3

Place them on the grid

Position each stakeholder in the appropriate quadrant.

4

Plan engagement strategy

Use each quadrant's strategy to decide how much time and communication to invest.

5

Update regularly

Stakeholders can move between quadrants as the project progresses.

Community Needs Assessment: What to Measure and Why

What is a Needs Assessment? A systematic process of collecting and analysing information about a community to identify gaps between the current situation and what conditions should or could be. A good needs assessment is the evidence base that justifies your project design, ensures you are solving the right problem, and makes your proposal credible to funders and partners.

What to Measure: The Six Assessment Dimensions

Demographic Data

Know who lives in the community — age, gender, household size, employment. Without this baseline, you cannot define your target group or measure change.

How: Census data, local gov records, surveys

Existing Services & Resources

Understand what already exists before proposing new interventions. Duplication wastes resources; gaps reveal where your project adds value.

How: Directory of NGOs, government services, local businesses

Felt Needs

What do community members themselves say they need? Perceptions and priorities of the community must drive the project, not external assumptions.

How: Surveys, community meetings, focus groups

Expressed Needs

Demand that is already being shown through behaviour: how many people attend school, use clinics, access a service. Behaviour is more reliable than stated preference.

How: Attendance records, usage statistics, sign-up lists

Comparative Needs

How does this community compare to similar communities, to national averages, or to a recognised standard? Identifies whether this is a local problem or systemic.

How: National surveys, policy benchmarks, research reports

Barriers to Access

Even when services exist, communities may not use them due to cost, distance, stigma, language, or distrust. Identifying barriers is essential for designing accessible solutions.

How: Interviews, observations, focus groups

Needs Assessment: Methods and the Assessment Cycle

Data Collection Methods

Surveys / Questionnaires

Structured, standardised forms distributed to a sample. Best for quantitative data. Fast and cost-effective at scale, but limited in depth.

Limitation: Cannot capture nuance; may miss hidden issues

Key Informant Interviews

One-on-one conversations with experts, leaders, or insiders who have deep knowledge of the community. Provides rich, contextual insight.

Limitation: Time-intensive; risk of biased informants

Focus Group Discussions

Guided group conversation (6–10 participants) exploring a topic. Captures community dynamics, shared views, and divergent opinions.

Limitation: Dominant voices may suppress others; needs skilled facilitation

Observation

Direct, systematic observation of activities, environments, or behaviours. Useful for understanding context that people may not articulate.

Limitation: Time-consuming; researcher presence can alter behaviour

Secondary Data Review

Analysis of existing reports, records, statistics, and research. Essential starting point before field data collection.

Limitation: Data may be outdated or not specific to your community

The Needs Assessment Cycle

1

Define Scope & Purpose

What decision will this assessment inform? Who are the beneficiaries? What is the geographic or demographic boundary?

2

Review Existing Data

Search for existing studies, statistics, reports, and assessments before collecting new data. Avoid duplicating existing knowledge.

3

Select Methods & Sample

Choose data collection methods. Decide sample size and how you will ensure representation (especially of marginalised groups).

4

Collect Data

Conduct surveys, interviews, focus groups. Maintain ethical standards: informed consent, confidentiality, voluntary participation.

5

Analyse & Interpret

Look for patterns, gaps, and priorities. Distinguish between needs expressed by community members and needs identified by data.

6

Report & Validate

Share findings with stakeholders, especially the community. Allow them to confirm, correct, or add nuance to your findings.

Designing Surveys: Question Types & When to Use Them

Survey design is one of the most technically demanding parts of a needs assessment. The type of question you use determines the type of data you get. Choosing the wrong type leads to answers that cannot be analysed or compared.

Closed / Dichotomous

Format: Yes / No or True / False

Use when: Simple factual facts, screening questions

✦ **Advantage:** Easy to analyse, quick for respondents

✗ **Limitation:** No depth; forces a binary on complex issues

Multiple Choice (Single)

Format: Select one option from a list

Use when: Mutually exclusive categories

✦ **Advantage:** Comparable across respondents; easy to tabulate

✗ **Limitation:** May miss options; forces categorisation

Multiple Choice (Multi-Select)

Format: Select all that apply

Use when: When respondent may have multiple relevant answers

✦ **Advantage:** Captures real complexity

✗ **Limitation:** Harder to analyse; popularity bias

Likert Scale

Format: 1–5 or 1–7 agreement scale

Use when: Measuring attitudes, perceptions, satisfaction

✦ **Advantage:** Captures degree of opinion; statistically usable

✗ **Limitation:** Respondents cluster in the middle; cultural interpretation differs

Ranking

Format: Put options in order of importance

Use when: Prioritisation — understanding what matters most

✦ **Advantage:** Shows real priorities; forces trade-off thinking

✗ **Limitation:** Difficult to complete; hard to aggregate across respondents

Open-Ended

Format: Free text response

Use when: Exploring themes, gathering stories, understanding context

✦ **Advantage:** Rich, unexpected insights; respondent's own language

✗ **Limitation:** Cannot be easily quantified; time-consuming to analyse

Survey Design: Common Mistakes and How to Fix Them

Leading Questions

✗ Bad: *Don't you agree that the government is failing our community?*

✓ Better: How would you rate the government's performance in serving your community? ☐ Very good ☐ Good ☐ Fair ☐ Poor ☐ Very poor

Why it matters: Leading questions suggest the 'right' answer, contaminating your data to reflect your assumptions rather than community views.

Double-Barrelled Questions

✗ Bad: *Do you use the health clinic and school regularly?*

✓ Better: Split into two questions: (1) Do you use the health clinic regularly? (2) Do you use the school regularly?

Why it matters: If a respondent only uses one, how do they answer? You will get meaningless data you cannot disaggregate.

Jargon and Unclear Language

✗ Bad: *How often do you utilise municipal infrastructure for recreational activities?*

✓ Better: How often do you use public parks or playgrounds in your area?

Why it matters: Respondents should not need a dictionary to complete your survey. Unclear language produces confused, inaccurate answers.

Loaded / Emotional Language

✗ Bad: *Have you suffered from the lack of proper healthcare in this area?*

✓ Better: How would you describe the quality of healthcare available in your area?

Why it matters: Loaded language frames the answer before the question is complete. It also alienates respondents who don't share that framing.

No 'Not Applicable' Option

✗ Bad: *How often do you use public transport?* ☐ Daily ☐ Weekly ☐ Monthly ☐ Never

✓ Better: Add: ☐ N/A – there is no public transport in my area. Or: ☐ I do not have access to public transport.

Why it matters: Forcing a 'Never' answer from someone who has no transport option creates false data about preferences vs. access.

Too Long / No Order Logic

✗ Bad: *50+ questions in random order with no logical flow between topics*

✓ Better: Group questions by theme. Start with easy, non-sensitive items. Place sensitive questions later once trust is built. Keep surveys under 20 minutes.

Why it matters: Survey fatigue causes rushed, inaccurate answers near the end and high abandonment rates before completion.

Interview Techniques: Probing Questions

Interviews are the most powerful qualitative data collection tool — but also the most easily compromised by poor technique. Probing is the skill of asking follow-up questions that draw out deeper, richer, and more specific information.

The Basic Probe

Silence, or a simple 'Can you tell me more about that?' after a short or vague answer.

Do not rush to fill silence — respondents often give their most candid answers after a brief pause. Silence is a tool, not an awkward gap.

- 'Could you say a bit more about that?'
- 'Can you expand on that for me?'

The Clarification Probe

Used when an answer is vague, ambiguous, or uses a term that could mean different things.

Never assume you know what a term means. 'Community,' 'fair,' 'safe' mean very different things to different people.

- 'When you say ____, what do you mean exactly?'
- 'How would you define ____ in this context?'

The Elaboration Probe

Moves the respondent from a general statement to specific, concrete, evidence-based detail.

General statements are hard to analyse. Concrete examples ground data in real experience and reveal what actually happens.

- 'Could you give me a specific example of that?'
- 'Can you describe a time when you experienced that?'

The Verification Probe

Used when answers earlier in the interview appear to contradict something said later.

Contradictions often reveal important nuance or complexity — they are frequently where the most useful insights live.

- 'Earlier you said ____. Can you help me understand how that connects to what you just said?'
- 'That seems different from what you said before — can you help me reconcile those two points?'

Interview Techniques: Maintaining Neutrality

Neutrality does not mean being cold or robotic — it means not influencing what the respondent says. Your reactions, word choices, and body language all send signals. Any signal of approval or disapproval changes what the respondent tells you next.

Do Not Express Agreement or Disagreement

✗ Avoid: *'That's really interesting!' / 'Good point!' / 'I completely agree.'*

Why: These create social pressure on the respondent to keep saying things you seem to like — and to withhold anything you might disapprove of. Your data will reflect what you seem to want, not what is true.

✓ Instead: Use neutral acknowledgements: *'I see.' / 'I understand.'* / *'Thank you for sharing that.'* / *'Mm-hmm.'*

Do Not Show Visible Surprise or Shock

✗ Avoid: *Widening your eyes, leaning back, saying 'Oh wow!' or 'Really?!' at unexpected answers.*

Why: Visible surprise signals to the respondent that they have said something unusual or wrong. They will then soften, retract, or reframe their answer to be more 'acceptable' — losing the very insight you needed.

✓ Instead: Maintain a calm, curious, open expression throughout. Practice your neutral face before difficult interviews.

Do Not Lead with Your Hypothesis

✗ Avoid: *'You probably find it hard because of the distance, right?' / 'I imagine cost is the main barrier?'*

Why: Once you name a possible answer, respondents are far more likely to confirm it — even if it isn't accurate. This is called 'leading' and it contaminates your findings with your prior assumptions.

✓ Instead: Ask open questions: *'What makes it difficult for you to access this service?'* — then let the respondent answer in their own words.

Do Not Repeat or Rephrase in a Way That Editorialises

✗ Avoid: *'So what you're saying is that the situation is really terrible and nothing is being done?'*

Why: Paraphrasing that adds emphasis, moral framing, or emotional charge distorts what the respondent actually said. It also signals what you want to hear.

✓ Instead: Reflect back neutrally: *'So if I understand correctly, you're saying that [neutral summary of what they said]? Is that right?'*

Interview Ethics: Informed Consent

Research ethics are not optional formalities — they are the foundation of trust between researchers and communities. Violating ethical standards can cause direct harm to participants, invalidates your findings, and permanently damages your credibility as a researcher.

Informed Consent: The Five Requirements

1 Disclosure

Participants must be told, in plain language: who you are, what the research is for, what you will do with their data, and who will have access to it. No deception or withholding of key information is permitted.

2 Comprehension

Information must be provided in the participant's own language and at a level they can genuinely understand. You must check that they understood — not just that you explained. A nod is not comprehension.

3 Voluntariness

Participation must be entirely voluntary. There must be no pressure, no incentive large enough to be coercive, and no negative consequence for declining or stopping at any point.

4 Competence

The participant must be mentally and legally capable of giving consent. For minors (under 18) or vulnerable adults, guardian consent AND participant assent are both required before proceeding.

5 Right to Withdraw

Participants may stop the interview at any time, for any reason, without any penalty or obligation to explain themselves. If they withdraw, all data collected from them must be discarded.

Interview Ethics: Core Principles for Community Research

These principles apply to all forms of community data collection — surveys, interviews, focus groups, and observation. They are not optional and they cannot be traded off against each other.

Do No Harm



Never conduct research in ways that cause psychological, social, physical, or economic harm to participants. Consider not just obvious harm but indirect harm — who could be affected if your findings were misused or became public? Design your research to protect participants from all foreseeable harms.

Examples:

- Avoid questions that re-traumatise survivors
- Do not publish data that could identify and endanger participants
- Stop an interview immediately if a participant becomes distressed

Confidentiality



Names and identifying details must never appear in research reports. Use participant codes or pseudonyms. Store all raw data (notes, recordings, transcripts) in a secure, password-protected location. Destroy data when it is no longer needed for the research.

Examples:

- Use codes: 'Participant 04' not 'Maria, 32, teacher'
- Never discuss specific responses publicly, even without names
- Lock physical notes; password-protect digital files

Anonymity



Where possible, design data collection so that even the researcher cannot link responses to specific individuals. This is stronger than confidentiality and is especially important for sensitive topics where identification could put participants at risk.

Examples:

- Anonymous surveys with no name or code fields
- Use drop boxes rather than hand-in to prevent linking respondent to response
- Aggregate data so individual profiles cannot be reconstructed

Data Security



Protect all data from the moment it is collected. Do not share raw interview notes, recordings, or transcripts with anyone outside the research team. Follow data minimisation principles — collect only the data you actually need. Have a clear data retention and destruction schedule.

Examples:

- Encrypted storage for digital recordings
- Physical notes locked in a secure drawer
- Clear retention policy: destroy after X months

Reciprocity



The community gave you their time and trust. Return value. Share your findings with the community in a format they can understand and use. Involve them in recommendations. Respect their time constraints. Acknowledge their contribution. Do not extract data and disappear — this damages trust for all future researchers.

Examples:

- Share a plain-language summary of findings
- Invite community members to help interpret results
- Acknowledge contributors in any published outputs

Key Takeaways

A Our biases are invisible to us — the first step is recognising they exist.

A Propaganda works on emotions and identity, not just false facts.

A Seeing is no longer believing — verify before you share.

A Use Author, Evidence, Motive, and Triangulation to evaluate every source.

B Treat the symptom and the problem will return. Find the root cause.

B Map ALL stakeholders — especially those who oppose you.

B A needs assessment is evidence, not guesswork. Let data guide design.

B Good questions produce good data. Bad questions produce misleading data.

B Every participant deserves full informed consent and the right to withdraw.